OPTIMISM VS. PESSIMISM AS OUTCOME VS. PROCESS

In this book, we offer divergent theoretical views as to nuclear weapons' effects on the South Asian security environment. How far apart are our competing positions? Do we share any common ground? We maintain that, despite our differences, our arguments are not wholly at odds with each other. While nuclear optimist and pessimist positions are sometimes seen as opposites, the differences between the two camps may be exaggerated. Both of us agree that nuclear weapons proliferation will not lead to the deliberate outbreak of large-scale war in South Asia. Neither Indian nor Pakistani leaders wish to initiate a conflict that could end in catastrophic losses or, potentially, national annihilation. We differ, however, on the importance that we assign to the possibility that catastrophic conflict could occur even though neither the Indians nor the Pakistanis intend it. Ganguly, and optimists generally, recognize that large-scale conflict, including nuclear escalation, could eventually occur in a nuclear environment; they do not claim that such an outcome is impossible. They focus, however, on the relatively benign nature of past history. Despite strained relations and numerous crises, India and Pakistan have consistently managed to avoid large-scale war or nuclear confrontation, thanks in large part to nuclear weapons' pacifying effects. In Ganguly's view, the future is likely to resemble the past, with nuclear deterrence preventing catastrophe, even in the face of continued tensions and disputes. Thus disaster in a nuclear South Asia remains highly unlikely.

Kapur, and pessimists generally, acknowledge that disaster has not occurred in a nuclear South Asia; they recognize that India and Pakistan have managed to avoid large-scale conflict and catastrophic escalation despite heightened regional tensions and continued crises. These scholars, however, emphasize the considerable dangers inherent in repeated Indo-Pakistani confrontations. Despite past crises' relatively benign outcomes, India and Pakistan have only narrowly avoided large-scale conventional and potentially even nuclear conflict. Moreover, nuclear deterrence